

Bluff

YOUR WAY THROUGH

Web 2.0 Technologies

Ah, so you've mastered the jargon, but how much can you spew about the *important* stuff? **AJAX:** This technology allows Webmasters to reload or process only specific sections of the Web page. This means that content on a page can be updated without the reloading the entire page.

Widget: A piece of code that allows you to add dynamic functionality to Web pages. For example, a status widget on your blog that lets readers know when you're online.

XML: The Extensible Markup Language allows Webmasters to define their own elements when creating a Web page. This allows for sharing of data across multiple sources linked together with the same element names on the Internet. **FOAF:** An acronym for Friend of a Friend, this is the structure used by social networking sites to describe people's profiles—name, country and how you are related to another person. Computers use these structures to find matching elements when running a search, like for users staying in Hyderabad.

XFN: The XHTML Friends Network is an attribute, which you can use in a blog or Web page to define a relationship when linking to another person. E.g.

Web APIs: These are interfaces for letting Web developers interact with other Web applications and allow them to extract and present data across Web pages on the Internet.

Usage

I use *XFN* on all my blog links. This is picked up by the *XML* elements in *FOAF* profiles of Social networking sites and that gives me a better search ranking on Google. I also use *AJAX* to run all the *Widgets* on my blog and I hope to learn the use of *Web APIs* soon.

Wild Wild Web

WikiTrash!

There's actually a *Wikipedia* page—http://en.wikipedia.org/wiki/Wikipedia:Unusual_articles—that lists out weird articles with links. Some are so weird, you'd wonder why Wikipedia doesn't edit them out; you could (and perhaps should) spend a lazy Sunday afternoon at this page, clicking the links.

So well, to convince you about that Sunday afternoon, here's a sampler (article name followed by description).

Pig War: A war between the United States and the British Empire that almost erupted over one dead pig.

Sisters of Perpetual Indulgence: An organization of

mostly gay men who dress as nuns, often on rollerskates.

Guilty not proven: A controversial Scots law verdict for those neither guilty nor innocent.

Vril: A belief that aliens controlled Nazi Germany and helped Hitler and others to escape to the South Pole when the war was lost.

The Significance Of Six

We swear on our paychecks the following was on a *real MIT Web page* a little while ago. The author now has it up on a Geocities page (www.geocities.com/tagonist/britneyanalysis/index.html), after complaints that the page was too frivolous for MIT, no doubt. Well, it's about

the lyrics in Britney Spears' songs, with commentary. Here's about the first stanza of *Oops*:
Yeah yeah yeah yeah yeah
Yeah yeah yeah yeah yeah
"Critical Analysis": "The 12 'yeah's set an affirmative tone for the rest of the song, which, as we shall see, actually sets up the pivotal irony, which is that the message of the song is actually one of negation and rejection. This ironic structure parallels the theme of the song in that its initial tone of acceptance and joy are actually false pretences, which will later be revealed as a miscommunication. The significance of the 12 is unclear; the 12 months, disciples, and signs of the zodiac are some theories."

from participating in future CES events, and it's likely that when it comes to handing out press passes, organisers wouldn't want to touch Gizmodo with a barge pole. Talk about shooting yourself in the foot.

LEGAL SPAM

Blind Justice

They say the law is an ass. Well, we do, anyway. While you normally don't expect courts to understand the technicalities of all the cases that come for decision, they are expected to follow some common sense while delivering the judgements. Or is it that common sense as defined by the law and common sense which is understood by us folks are two different things?

David Ritz was an anti-spam researcher who had suspicions that Sierra Corporate Designs, a Web hosting company was hosting spammers, or was actually involved in spamming. So what he did was routine: check the origin of the spam and attempt to trace it back. Several

commands were used for this tracing—all ordinary tools that your average system administrator would use in such a scenario. Among them were Unix commands like "host -l" which causes the execution of zone transfer. In plain English, this means accessing information that is stored on a DNS server for public viewing. When Sierra found out that Ritz was accessing this information which could be used against it, they filed a court case to prohibit Ritz to access this (publicly available!) information. And surprise, surprise, it won.

Most of the case documents have been sealed under court orders, but from what is available on the Net, it seems that the unfortunate Ritz was convicted and fined \$60,000 (Rs 24,00,000), because he performed the online analogy of looking up information available in a public document and using that information to nail a crime. Anyone would agree that this cannot be considered unauthorized access. Anyone with sense, anyway. What's giving



becomes outdated. Maybe there should be a special school for these judges. That would make such bloopers redundant.

WOOF

Dog Day

How do you know what your pug is thinking of when it is barking madly at you? Some ingenious gadget maker from Japan had made a similar device for cats, and we had predicted that similar things ought to be out for man's best friend. We knew we were good, but we didn't know we were this good. We also didn't realise that *Digit* had a readership in Hungary.

Okay, about that Hungarian readership statistics part—we made it up. But what we didn't make up is the human understanding dog part. Scientists at Budapest's ELTE University have designed software that figures out the emotional response of dogs to different situations. Fourteen canine volunteers were exposed to different

iGo

We never really expected it to happen. Ram—our innocent, spaced out, blissfully inebriated Ram—has quit smoking. We don't know what to make of this. Before, if we saw no Ram at his desk, we'd naturally assume he's in the smoking bay. Now, when we see no Ram at desk, we panic.

Not that it matters any more, though. You see, Ram has discovered that there's a Real World outside *Digit* (well, so they tell us) and by the time you read this, he'll have set out to see what's really out there. Maybe he'll meet a fire-breathing dragon, and maybe it'll light him a cigarette he won't smoke. We don't know. We will miss him, though, despite all the practise we've got from his frequent disappearances.

In other news, we had ourselves a late-night visit

Digit Diary

from someone rather special—or rather, someone attached to something rather special—the iPhone. Picture a room full of women around a baby—pinching, prodding, saying things like, "Aww, cho chweeeet!"—only replace the women with untidy male geeks, and the baby with the iPhone, and change the words to something more manly like, "The Force is strong in this one". That's what it was like.

Zivalal's bike got itself towed the other day, and this has made him rather jumpy—"Main Vashi nahin jayega!" (I won't go to Vashi!). You know how the office grapevine is—the story was twisted, and as of this writing, the women are worried he's some sort of sex offender (he's not).

Ah, well. Another month, another scandal...

situations guaranteed to pique their interest—getting a treat, playing with a ball, meeting a stranger, fighting with other dogs—situations that usually make dogs bark loud enough to wake the dead. In the present case, the dogs barked loud enough, and with sufficient emotion to make the code in the software perform function calls, execute loops, and check boundary conditions; basically go

through the motions which produce results.

This dog-deciphering software had a much better strike rate than human ears, as it could understand the cause of barks, yaps, howls and growls more accurately than humans could. The inventors acknowledge that they could do better, and the software is no where near perfect. A possible use of such

software is in human-dog interaction, though what could be the possible use of understanding whether the dog is ecstatic or simply happy escapes us. Maybe it would promote better understanding between *Homo sapiens* and *Canis lupus familiaris*—that is always laudable. Maybe it would enable an invention that would make dogs understand! Now that'd be a gizmo to buy.

Blog WATCH

Microsoft plans to discontinue sales of Windows XP from June 30, 2007 and there is already an online petition against this move. We track the blogosphere to follow the reactions.

Steve Bralovich

Save Windows XP Petition

<http://pdatoday.blogspot.com/2008/01/save-windows-xp-petition.html> (<http://tinyurl.com/35rk8k>)
Microsoft would like to end nearly all sales of Windows XP on June 30th of this year, in spite of hesitance by many businesses and individuals about moving to Vista. Such a pricey, time-consuming shift with questionable benefits should not be forced on Windows users, so InfoWorld has decided to rally XP users to demand that XP be kept available.

With 27 years of computer and tech experience, I never make a change of operating systems until I buy a new laptop or device. This assures me of the widest 3rd party software support and zero compatibility issues. Unless there's a compelling MUST HAVE reason, I stay away. This policy has served me well and I recommend that others do the same.

Jme Solivas

Law and ICT

<http://lawandict.blogspot.com/2008/01/xp-vs-vista-forcibly-replacing-old-with.html> (<http://tinyurl.com/2f8rgf>)

...Personally, I'd choose Old School XP over New Age Vista any day. Vista is just too darn slow, complicated, and bug-ridden. For me, it boasts of alleged value-

added features, but which I find are not really user friendly. Simply, there are still a lot of bugs to be fixed. I'm all for change, but the change has got to be for the better...

Mary Jo Foley

ZDNet Blogs

<http://blogs.zdnet.com/microsoft/?p=1109&tag=nl.e622> (<http://tinyurl.com/2uwads>)

...There are a couple of problems here. First, Windows XP is not being 'discontinued' on June 30. Instead, as of that date—unless the software maker issues another reprieve like it did in September 2007—Microsoft will no longer make XP available to OEMs for preloading and/or via retail sales.

Microsoft isn't pulling the plug on XP support this year. Mainstream (free) support for XP from Microsoft ends in April 2009. Extended support (free for security fixes and paid for other help) ends in 2014.

Infoworld is advocating for Microsoft to continue to offer XP indefinitely. Fat chance. Why would Microsoft give customers more incentives not to upgrade to Vista—beyond the ones it has inadvertently provided by delivering a first-generation product that had driver and application compatibility issues; performance problems; and reliability glitches?